Ajahn Sumedho - **00:00**

And reflect on it. Last week it was stress and its cessation that attracted a lot of people. Life hurts. But in this evening, this afternoon. And we can. I like to just contemplate how these kind of basic experiences of life, things that are just so ordinary, such as happiness and unhappiness, what they really are and how, you know. Because sometimes our life is caught up in all kinds of anticipations and. And assumptions about things. And I found that even when happiness. When there is happiness, we seldom can really fully appreciate it. Because the mind is conditioned to go on to the next thing. So that when something's really going right and everything is extraordinarily pleasant, Something in us is programmed to go on to something else. Just because the programming is that way. To be able to relax and to just be.

Ajahn Sumedho - **01:31**

To have the confidence and the trust in just being conscious and aware. Because sometimes we feel very guilty if we're not busy going somewhere, doing something. Going on to the next thing. In a reflection on Life hurts is trying to bring our attention to that. Life basically is an experience of great sensitivity. It has a lot of feeling in it. It's this way, no matter how fortunate or unfortunate the particular things that happen to us might be. Just if you contemplate just your own physical presence, just having the human body, what is it like as an experience? And when you contemplate it and not judge it, don't try to make any strong statements about it, but just notice, be aware of what it is to be conscious within the physical form, the sensitive form that we have.

Ajahn Sumedho - **02:50**

You can see it is basically quite a situation that provides us with a lot of physical pain, discomfort. And that life itself brings a lot of disappointments and. And disillusionments to us. Maybe we expect too much from life. When we're young and idealistic and don't have a lot of experience. We sometimes expect life to be something that we find out later. It's really not that way. Then the mind easily goes into blame and either towards oneself or towards other people. But when you contemplate life hurts, then something in us says, yeah, that's all right. Why shouldn't it? That's the way it is. Then why should we expect it to be otherwise? And in that, then it's not a kind of bitter resignation to. To a bad experience, but it's an acceptance of the sensitive state that we're in.

Ajahn Sumedho - **04:07**

And all the possible experiences that we know that we can imagine. We begin to. Instead of dreading or fearing, we began to just take our lives and learn from them, learn what we can, from what happens to us. Life itself is, you know, as far as we know. Our understanding of it is this way. It's planetary life, its physical existence, its sensitivity. Life to us oftentimes means the life of our body. So that we. Because we tend to identify so strongly and make assumptions about ourselves as being this physical form. That we assume that when this form dies, that's the end of life. We can see that the logic there. That the death of a human body means that life is no longer present. But when you begin to contemplate it more and more. Investigate it for what it really is.

Ajahn Sumedho - **05:31**

You begin to notice that this body is just something that is temporarily operating within the experience of life. And that because it was born, it will die. And when time has come for it to die, then that's the natural. That's what's natural for it. And we begin to see that. Understand more the amata, or the deathless reality. Rather than see the end of life as a physical death. It's also a kind of conceit, ingrained conceit in just the way we think, isn't it? That we assume that once we die, that's the end of life. What about when we're asleep? You know, what happens to the world when we're asleep? Because we're no longer conscious of anything other than, say, maybe a few dreams that might go through the mind at that time. Or what happened in the.

Ajahn Sumedho - **06:46**

You know, in the rest of the world. All that's happening, say, in London today or in Paris or in Bosnia or wherever we can. We can contemplate as being. You know, we assume that it's other human beings are doing exactly the same thing that we're doing or thinking, feeling conscious beings that are having maybe moments of happiness or sorrow or despair. But as an actual experience. Now, we don't know. We know that we're feeling at this moment. We know we can know what's going through our mind. We. We can observe the pleasure or the pain, the doubt or the despair or the indifference or the fear or the happiness or the joy that we might be experiencing at this moment. That we can know for sure. And so the Buddha's teaching is aimed at that kind of awareness of.

Ajahn Sumedho - **07:59**

Of seeing how the qualities of the conditioned realm are fleeting. They come and go, and they move very quickly. They change. They're unstable. You can't stabilize them. You can't make them last. It's their nature to begin and end. But in that reflection, you begin to ask yourself Questions like what is it that can be aware of all this? Who is it that knows this? What is it that watches? And that throws us back onto, say just that attentive awareness. Because you can't find out what is aware, you can only be aware. And this is where we want, what we need to trust in is just that, being aware.

Ajahn Sumedho - **09:09**

That willingness to just be with this conscious state, with whatever happens to be going on, noting it, accepting it, reflecting upon it, contemplating it, but not making, no longer just rushing around, trying to go on to the next thing to distract ourselves into something else. Like the cessation of stress is the willingness to relax and stay with the way things are, no matter what they might be, with the experiences of life. And notice how in the newspapers and the mass media and just on the telephones and just the gossip or the experiences of just our own family or acquaintances, the things that happened in the world such as divorce, infidelity, adultery, neglect, child abuse, criminal activities, lying, corruption, all of these kind of subjects are always news for us.

Ajahn Sumedho - **10:45**

But what did they actually do to the mind when we hear about, say, the misfortunes of famous people? What is so fascinating really about say, the unhappiness or the failures or misfortunes of famous people? Why do we give so much importance to the royal family of this country? Why do we care so much about, why are we so interested in what they do and so we can. Because, you know, when we contemplate this, we begin to realize our own humanity is the same that we tend to think of ourselves maybe as not being an important or significant figure in the society, but yet we still have the same life hurt experiences. And I don't think we delight, particularly delight in the misery of the rich and glamorous and famous.

Ajahn Sumedho - **11:56**

But it does help us to realize that it's part of life experience, that everyone gets their fair share of it, no matter who they are. And nobody's really going to get out of it that much. Because life is like this. We reflect every day. We are the owners of our karma, heir to our karma, born of our karma. So this word karma in Buddhist terminology is quite significant because it's about just the results of having been born and having done the things that we've done, having said the things that we've said, having experienced the things that we've experienced. Sometimes because it is a bit of an exotic word we can empower, it has a little more impact. Maybe we just say cause and effect is a bit bland and not quite so Glamorous. And yet some of us would maybe prefer that.

Ajahn Sumedho - **13:06**

Because karma always kind of has the sound of the exotic Orient or some Hindu kind of esoteric, special quality to it. Because it's not an English word. And yet you hear it being used quite regularly in ordinary parlance about my

karma and her karma. Karma of Britain, karma of Bosnia Herzegovina. But what we really mean, isn't it that. And that the results. The result. Now say this is a resultant karma, the way it is right now, say just having left your home and come here. The result of that is that you're here. Why aren't you somewhere else? And what you're feeling and hearing and all that is the resultant karma of having made the effort to say, get up and get into your car and drive here and come into this hall and sit down.

Ajahn Sumedho - **14:30**

So it's not anything other than just the most kind of sensible or, you know, quite ordinary experience. So we can observe the resultant karma in any moment. It's interesting to. As you begin to appreciate your ability to do this, you begin to. One feels a real interest in life, in what happens. And it doesn't have to be anything special either. Because you're not thinking that you need special kind of extreme experiences for your life anymore. You don't need to have adventures and fantastic special events to live your life. Because just the ordinariness of life is what you begin to look at and observe. Where before maybe you didn't. Maybe you just ignored that. There's so much that one can just. Just not pay attention to and pass over. Because it doesn't seem significant. We've not given it any significance in our lives.

Ajahn Sumedho - **15:44**

And yet just the effect of having demands made on you. Or we can start resenting it isn't there if somebody starts demanding things from us, or if. If we hear some rather threatening news or the neighbors start complaining, or you hear a possibility of losing your job or failing the examination or even passing the examination, whatever. These kind of perceptions affect our consciousness. And we can. And we can merely kind of ignore this. In fact, much of life can be just an escape from. Just a way of kind of avoiding these things. Because we tend to worry. We worry about passing the examination or what the neighbors will say, or whether we'll keep our job or whether it will be sunny tomorrow, it'll be cold and wet, or. Or whether, you know, our lives will be.

Ajahn Sumedho - **16:58**

We'll be able to maintain them in the same way as we get older. So that even though these are worries for us, the worrying part of Our life tends to be one of just going on to the next thing. It's not resolving anything. One's just caught up in a series of unpleasant mental states that lead to a sense of despair or annoyance or exasperation. And then we want to get out of it, get away from it, distract ourselves into something that will stop this kind of proliferation. So instead of doing that, we think life hurts. It feels like this when I hear. When the neighbors complain or somebody criticizes me, it feels this way.

Ajahn Sumedho - **17:52**

I remember years ago in Thailand, there was some monks, Western monks, they had just come from the United States and recently ordained, and they'd been reading about these confrontations that were very popular back in the early 70s in America, where people would confront each other. They would say, you know, I think that you're this way, or I feel that you're that way, or whatever feeling they happen to be feeling towards you, they kind of tell you immediately. And so they were talking about and that this was probably a very good thing to do. And I could feel his inner terror arising really strong, almost like, you know, quite a strong fear arose when I thought, these monks are going to really make my life unbearable because they're going to confront me every day that I'm with them.

Ajahn Sumedho - **19:01**

We won't be able to just pass the day being pleasant to each other and avoiding issues totally, but we're always going to have to go around kind of saying, why did you look cross eyed at me? Or why? And there's a. Because one really hasn't really maybe fully admitted to oneself the fears and the hurt and the disappointments of one's own life and maybe has developed a whole kind of lifestyle around avoidance and just being. Putting on an act, really, or passing things off or dismissing. When you hear of someone that is quite frank and forthright in what they say, one tends to. Just the thought of them tends to bring forth a sense of fear or threat. And you can actually feel that. You

can actually be aware of that feeling.

Ajahn Sumedho - **20:07**

This is what I found very helpful, is to reflect on that feeling. Why do I start shaking when people say, I want to share something with you? Tomato the California. And then you think, oh, I'm in for it now. They're going to say things that will hurt me, that will offend me, that will distress my mind. And so because, you know, they say my own background was a background of avoidance. Family I grew up in, were all kind of determined to not address real issues, but to always put on a good face and a stiff upper lip and make the best of life, as they said, which worked all right in some cases, but it also made you very unable to relate very deeply to anyone else, because the only way you knew how to do was to.

Ajahn Sumedho - **21:20**

To be rather nice and bland and go around pretending that everything's all right. And in that, of course, you felt the result was a sense of never really getting to know anyone and always feeling a bit threatened or frightened at the possibility of anything deeper than just a banal, super sort of surface pleasantries. And yet each one of us, I think, longs to get in there and kind of break into the real stuff. I mean, there's something in us also that wants to know the truth and wants to be liberated from our own fears and our own imprisonment of habits and attitudes. I was reading about some woman poet who is. One of her great lines was invade my privacy. This was like a cry from a person who lived very private life and had all the kind of the defenses up to make.

Ajahn Sumedho - **22:42**

That's exactly what they wanted. And yet there's also this longing for it to be invaded, to be taken away from one, not to be left in this state of just kind of safe isolation from life and from the feeling of life. One could even look at monasticism as that way of a kind of avoidance. And it can be used like that because monastic life is disciplined. It's based on. On a high level of etiquette, duties and obligations to each other. And therefore it. And it can be idealized into, you know, what a really good monk should be, a good nun should be, and it can.

Ajahn Sumedho - **23:34**

We can get terribly inspired by the idealism of Buddhist monasticism, but in the actual nitty gritty of daily life, one finds that in Sangha life or the community life of monastics, you're constantly having to kind of open your heart up to what's actually taking place. You. You have to, when you're living with each other, the system of, say, obligations, duties and that to each other based on. On morality. So we. We're not, you know, there's no. We have a strong sense of. Of respecting each other in regards to, you know, the property and the physical body itself and the spiritual aspiration of each member of the Sangha. So, I mean, that's something that we must reflect upon and treasure and protect. But in the process of getting on with daily life, all our kind of faults and weaknesses appear.

Ajahn Sumedho - **24:53**

We can't maintain the stiff upper lip. It's a kind of permanent, petrified posture, can you? You can't keep the lip stiff all that for very long when it starts trembling. And then also it's over the years, things, you know, when one develops, as you're developing, say, meditation, mindfulness, around the way things are, you become more willing to look at things. You feel more confident that you can actually look at your fears and observe them and accept them. Look at the anxiety or the worry or the doubt in your mind, Do I really want to be a monk or a nun? Is this really what I want to do with my life? And look at that rather than feel that you shouldn't be thinking like that.

Ajahn Sumedho - **26:01**

Or you begin to look at your own, say, lustful tendencies, ways that you tend to those desires in one that want some

kind of sensual pleasure or satisfaction, or the anger or the jealousy, the envy or the feelings of self, lack of self worth. One begins to take an interest in these things, take an interest rather than think that these. Then look at these things as something that are in your way, something that is blocking your spiritual development or something that shouldn't be or you shouldn't be like that. You begin to take an interest in the way it is what the fears, the worries, the tendencies of the mind, no matter how. And some of them can be quite, you know, quite heavy in regards to their quality.



Ajahn Sumedho - **27:22**

Or they can be maybe just unnoticed tendencies of your life that you just been so used to. You've never. You've never had any perspective upon. But yet they do leave you at the end of the day, maybe with a feeling of incredible loneliness or feeling of resentment, because it's not always that terrible. I mean, really dreadful or unfortunate things have happened to us that have ruined our lives. But there can be a whole series of. Of little experiences that have influenced the way we tend to react and see to the daily life that we have. One thing it's interesting to see the monks and nuns in regards to authority, because most of us have come from backgrounds where hierarchy is regarded as almost evil, bad.



Ajahn Sumedho - **28:39**

I mean, that's more so in America, I think, than in Britain, where American attitudes about hierarchy are that America, they're so idealistic. They. They think that everyone is ideally equal in every way. Men and women equal in every way. There's no difference. And all races, all classes, everybody is. Should be equal anyway, should be totally equal. And anything hierarchical then seems to be like something that shouldn't be. Which always leaves this sense of fear or resentment for those who in practical ways maybe are above us or better than we are or in positions of authority. It's interesting to see with the nuns and the Monks, the attitude of women towards men, just the feelings and that the nuns have about monks or being the male presence. Because theravada structure is very kind of highly male dominated form. It's a very masculine outfit.



Ajahn Sumedho - **30:14**

I wonder why the nuns want to be with us. They resent male authority so much. But these things are not to justify or to criticize, but to observe the feelings that one has in regards to these experiences. It's interesting to see when, sometimes when a nun has some authority in charge of things, how to see the way monks react to that. Because it works both ways. Bhikkhus, you know, bhikkhus are used to being the kind of the. The nuns usually defer to the bhikkhus. So sometimes a nun will have something that she's in charge of and she might get quite authoritative in that position. And it brings up very strong feelings in some of the monks, including myself. And so these are the very. This is the nitty gritty. This is the stuff of life hurts, isn't it?



Ajahn Sumedho - **31:48**

Where rather than ignoring these things, one looks at them, one watches, one embraces them and is willing to feel them. Because you know that this is the way to resolve those karmic, that kind of karma, rather than just, you know, go through the usual ways of reacting to it. One way I think that's very common among men is to just suppress, just ignore feeling. Because if the things get, you know, feelings get too much, you can just kind of turn the other way. Refused to look at it. And therefore the karma never is resolved. One is never. One is always caught reacting in the same way through one's whole life. Unless we learn to skillfully resolve these tendencies or these kind of hurting things of life as they happen to us.



Ajahn Sumedho - **33:04**

To be the senior figure in a community, be the patriarch, and to be able to fulfill that role within a community without becoming attached to it or becoming embarrassed by it. Because inevitably we relate to each other. We have to relate to each other in different ways. Somebody has to enter the doorway first. We all can't enter at the same moment. When we go through the line for the food, somebody has to go first. There has to be an agreement about

how we do things. And therefore say the conventions we do have are merely practical agreements to make life, to simplify life, to make it possible that this is not terribly confused. To have an order that we all agree to. And from that order, from that agreement, then it's possible to be mindful of what we actually feel.

Ajahn Sumedho - **34:30**

And we realize that in our lives, the more we are willing to actually feel life, to be hurt by life, to accept the slings and arrows, to accept the problems, the difficulties, the ups, the downs, the willingness to feel all of it, then we really can take an interest in our lives. When I was saying just a few minutes ago about this confrontation, years ago, this idea of confronting anyway the monks, we all decided to have a confrontation session one afternoon. And so we all met in a certain place, the appointed time. And I was petrified, but I wasn't willing to admit I was petrified. I was pretty pretending that I wasn't because you don't want to look like that. They might actually confront you with, why are you frightened? So pretended that I wasn't.

Ajahn Sumedho - **35:46**

And therefore one found myself kind of going to a level of kind of wisecracks or kind of silly humor is to kind of ease the tensions and make it not so important, kind of, you know, make it less threatening by filling my mind with rather silly thoughts and foolish jokes. Then one of the monks that was really into confrontation, he wanted us to confront him. That's a strange thing. I thought they were all going to have a go at me. But actually this monk wanted us to attack him. He seemed to have a great love need for being told off. So. And he is quite a difficult character. So some of the monks started saying, well, you know, why do you do this and why are you always late and why this and that? He seemed to quite enjoy being criticized. This is strange.

Ajahn Sumedho - **37:01**

So when it came my turn, he says, okay, Ajahn Sumedha, what have you got to say about me? I decided, instead of saying anything critical, I just decided to say what I found very nice about him. So I told him and he was furious. He thought I was lying. He thought I was afraid to tell him because this was a confrontation. His confrontation always have to be critical. We can confront each other with, you know, let me tell you about how wonderful you are rather than I've come to tell you how horrible you are or how much you annoy me. And then they finally it came my turn to be confronted. And every one of them said, well, we have nothing to say about you're okay.

Ajahn Sumedho - **38:01**

What a relief I got out of that one because I was really, you know, really quite terrified they were going to go in and hurt and bring up issues or subjects or things. Maybe they could see things in me that I wasn't aware of. Always that fear of having to find out something that you don't want to really know about anyway. And so there is a relief, the fact that somehow with me, I'd managed to get out of it. And I realize that has been very much a trend in my life, is managed to get out of a lot of things. And so I guess I've developed a kind of a character that everybody thinks is okay and that I'm perfectly normal and that they don't. People aren't so.

Ajahn Sumedho - **39:09**

Or else maybe I give off the impression that I'm so sensitive and that if they say anything, I'd probably be totally shattered by it. But anyway, my life has not been one where people have confronted me very much and had really said things that were all that shattering. And it's also. I appreciate that it's given me a chance to. To develop, say, mindfulness around the events of life, just the little things of life, just the annoyances or the exasperations that one experiences in daily life or because one. Because these opportunities were made, were available and made conscious. To me there was also an influence, the definite influence of the suggestion that it might be a good thing to really look and observe.

Ajahn Sumedho - **40:17**

And then reading the Buddhist teachings from that and the Satipatthana, the Four foundations of mindfulness, one began to see that actually Buddha was pointing to this. This in his own way. When he talks about the foundations of mindfulness, he's talking about just the physical body itself, one's own body with its senses, its eyes and ears and nose and tongue, the sensitivity of the whole form with its brain, with its nervous system, with its organs, with its breath, with its mental state, with the ability to feel, to be attracted, repelled through the senses, with the mind itself, with the memories that we have with the moods of the mind, the fears, the anguish, the despair, the loves and hates, the happiness, the disappointment, the hurts of life that the Buddha was, you know, be mindful of these.

Ajahn Sumedho - **41:28**

Know these things as they are for what they really are. Now, what they really are in terms of Dhamma is that they. They're impermanent and they're not self. And so I realized more and more why I was so frightened of this confrontation years ago was because I would take any criticism or anything that was mental or physical as something. It would be filled with a sense of being mine. And so, therefore, when you're so identified with your body, with your sensitivity, with your moods and memories, thoughts and tendencies, when that's so strong, such a strong identity, then one is, there's a level of anxiety always in the experience of life, because these are. We are terribly frightened of what others will say, or what will the neighbors think? What will my friends say, my colleagues? What will the monks and nuns think? What will.

Ajahn Sumedho - **42:47**

You know? It goes on and on into a tremendous self consciousness and fear of being looked down on or humiliated or despised or made fun of or jeered at. And yet, in terms of Dhamma, what we're doing is we're looking at all of this as it really is, as the fears, the desires, the feelings, the sensitivity, the body itself are put in the context of whatever is subject to arising, is subject to ceasing. Whatever is born, dies. And so then we're looking at the Dhamma of it, but we're still willing to feel it. It's not this sense of seeing, this way of contemplating impermanence. Isn't a dismissal just a kind of pushing things away and convincing ourselves that our feelings are not ours. It's not like you're trying to convince yourself it's not self.

Ajahn Sumedho - **44:02**

You're willing to feel, you're willing to be hurt, you're willing to experience this whole life experience in this form, in all its aspects, because you know, you begin to know very clearly. You realize the truth of it is that it's not. It's not yours. It's the karma of birth. It's the way it is. Pleasure and pain, praise and blame, happiness, suffering, success, failure. They appear, disappear. That's what the flow of life is about with these changing conditions. And we are now the observer, the witness, the one who is reflecting on it and seeing it for what it is, rather than the conditions themselves. And so instead of being somebody who's frightened or threatened by confrontation, instead of being that way, being somebody who's got these anxieties, you change from becoming somebody to being aware of this anxiety for what it is.

Ajahn Sumedho - **45:28**

And that means accepting it, letting it alone, let it be what it is, willing to let it be conscious, so you are feeling it and willing to bear with it, be patient, be accepting of it, and to not be so quick to judge it and make some critical comment or make a problem about it, just to let it be what it is. For example, if I say, in those early years when I was afraid of being confronted, there was also the thought, I shouldn't be afraid of being confronted, I should be afraid. This is probably good for me. It's what I need. I need to be told off. I need somebody to come and say, what's wrong with you? Is this? And I say, I'm just so weak, I can't take it, and I'm so frightened by it. But I shouldn't be that way.

Ajahn Sumedho - **46:24**

I should be brave. So you're caught in this endless kind of struggle in your mind thinking, oh, I don't want to. I couldn't bear it if they. If people said some things to me and then the other side comes up. But you should be, you know, you've got to conquer this fear. You should be brave. You should face life. You shouldn't be so cowardly. And then the other side, well, maybe later on, and maybe I should go to a therapist or something. This whole, you know, the way the mind will go from being this kind of wimpish, frightened being into this and then into the tyrant that says, you shouldn't be that way. And so that kind of war conflict goes on in the mind. But in mindfulness of it, both are just seen for what they are.



Ajahn Sumedho - **47:22**

It's this when the condition is frightened, anxious, worried, it's just this way. And you kind of listen and willing to feel it, like in your body, you go more towards, say, the chest or the stomach around here. You begin to note just what it. Like the kind of tensions you might be feeling, say, in the trunk of your body by that kind of anxiety or fear. And you can reflect with it, saying, it's all right to feel this way. You know, this is a kind of a way of encouraging yourself to not make any problem about it and to let it be what it is.



Ajahn Sumedho - **48:29**

And then if you go into the old tyrannical mode of, oh, you're so weak and so you shouldn't be this frightened and you need to go to a psychiatrist and all that, then you can, as soon as you're aware of that, the tyrant that's always coming down heavy with its moral judgments, value judgments, that feels like this. So you're also willing to feel the tyranny that in you that tends to detest and make criticisms about what you know about yourself. So it changes. You can't, you know, and you can't. At first it's difficult to always stay with it, but as you make a determination, resolution to do that, you begin to take an interest.



Ajahn Sumedho - **49:38**

It's interesting because what happens when you stay with something and you don't make any more karma with it, like when you're mindful of a mood or a state of mind or a feeling in the body, when you're really mindful of it, you accepted it and you're willing to let it be what it is, you're willing to coexist with it. Then it ceases. And in that sensation you've resolved that you're letting go. You're not making any karmic connection to it anymore. Because the karma is a reactiveness out of ignorance, isn't it? Where you follow it, you believe it. I'm so frightened, I can't bear this. And then the other is, you shouldn't be frightened, you should be brave. And then that's also you're making heavy karma with, through the tyrant or through the terribly sensitive, frightened personality.



Ajahn Sumedho - **50:51**

But that awareness, attentive awareness of it, is that you're not making a comma with the condition. You're letting it end, you're letting it go, you're letting it be what it is, it's impermanent, you're letting it cease according to its nature. And then you're tuning into the peace of the natural state of mind. When you're letting things cease in your mind, you're no longer caught up in just unskillful emotional reactions to things. That whole confusing, frustrating tendency starts fading out, diminishing, and you begin to realize the true nature of mind. We can call it bliss, peace, serenity, emptiness, empty minded or whatever. There are different ways of, different words that people use. But in that there's a sense of relief. Like I remember reading some Zen book years ago and they were describing the experience of Nibbana.



Ajahn Sumedho - **52:13**

It's like, you know, you've been carrying something heavy and you're very tired and then you put it down. That's Nibbana's like that or meeting a good friend at the crossroads, an old friend at the crossroads. I mean, these are not like, you know, ecstasies where you kind of just gone wild into a state of bliss that is just so fantastic. These are, these are happinesses that we. That are quite ordinary in daily life. But do you really notice them? Do you really notice them? Do you know like when you're really tired and you sit down and relax, Just that feeling of just being able

to relax. Can you really stay with that and notice the feeling of just rest? Or do you, or what do you do? You can just maybe feel tired and then rest, sit down to have a rest.

Ajahn Sumedho - **53:27**

But then your mind gets caught up with thinking about this or that. And so you don't even notice the nibbnic happiness or that sense of just being relaxed and at ease and trusting in that and noticing it. Last week's talk was on stress. And you can see like the term, the rat race and stress. The way Life has become such an ongoing, speedy experience. It seems like we're always going somewhere, always having to do something. There's this tension of a kind of urgency in everything. And so the rat race, we go back to the rat race or the. The stress of modern life, because it's much faster now, isn't it?

Ajahn Sumedho - **54:40**

All the technology has relieved us of a lot of kind of tedious chores, but in the process it speeded up everything because we now have to spend more time looking for things to do. And there's more interesting alternatives. There's always. You can go back to university when you're 60 years old. You can, you know, there's always a whole kind of menu, lists of things that are tantalizing possibilities to get involved with this or that. And the mind is very much conditioned to always be feeling it. There's something that you should be doing that you shouldn't be. Just being. I just want you to contemplate this. Is it very easy to just be and to trust in just being? Which doesn't mean that you don't do the dishes and don't go to work and you just decide you're going to be.

Ajahn Sumedho - **56:01**

Because life isn't like that, is it? Life is. Has its. We have our duties to perform and things like that in life. Just the needs of the body and so forth have their force and influence on our life. But we begin to kind of relax with the flow of life. We've gotten out of the rat race. We're not caught up in a compulsive pushiness of modern life. And when you do, when you feel that in your mind, when you feel that sense of I've got to do this and I should be doing that and just wasting time and all that, then you can take an interest in that feeling. Now, this next week, what I assign your homework, is to try to take time out during the day.

Ajahn Sumedho - **57:04**

You get kind of wound up and caught up into the rat race to take an interest in the feeling. Now, what does it feel like? Rather than. Than just thinking, criticizing yourself or. Here I go again, I'm caught up again. What does it feel like to feel like that and to kind of just take a look at your own body and the feeling or the mood of the mind and just question what is it really like? And accept it. Not question it, to judge it, but to just bring attention to it is enough. Just attention and see if you can just let it be the way it is. Just for a second is fine. You don't have to succeed in this at all, failure is completely allowable because this is not the rat race.

Ajahn Sumedho - **58:05**

So you don't have to prove that you can do it. I'm just suggesting this as a way that you can change your direction from just being helplessly caught up into the momentum of your habits and the intimidations of the world, to taking an interest in what's actually the way it is for you at this time. Not for the way it is, some ideal way it is, but the way it is now, as you are conscious of it at this moment. And to just reflect and note any kind of. Just this kind of thinking itself. What does it do to your mind? Does it make you feel insecure? Or what I'm saying, is it kind of threatening to you or is it interesting? Or just to note any emotional reaction you might have and just to. It's all right.

Ajahn Sumedho - **59:19**

Whatever reaction is there is the way it is and that willingness to let it be. The more you practice with this, then you'll

find that all the threats, fears, karma of your life will take you to peacefulness. You're beginning to see that even the hurts of life, the pain, the humiliations, the disappointments, even the worst side of life, not to mention just the little things of life. As you accept life for what it is, it all takes you to that inner peace of serenity of the heart, the peaceful mind. And when we say, and we contemplate Dhamma, the word Dhamma, or the truth of the way it is, we use this word openaiko. Leading inwards, it says, leading the truth takes us inwards. It takes us to Nibbana, to that realization of non attachment.



Ajahn Sumedho - **01:00:34**

And realization of non attachment isn't callous indifference and unwillingness to feel, but it's totally being the feeling, not becoming, but being with it and accepting and letting it be. And then you're allowing that which has arisen to cease. And in the cessation is the realization of life itself. Because you're letting the mortal things, the birth and death things, the beginning and ending things, you're breaking through the attachment you're breaking up, the illusions you have about them you've conquered death is one kind of heroic way of putting it. Or you realize the truth of the way it is. What do you think like death itself, what do you think when it's like the end, isn't it like your own death, your physical death, that's the end.



Ajahn Sumedho - **01:02:01**

Because that sense of death is very much connected to your body, your identity with the body and the memories and attitudes of mind. That you developed. But with mindfulness and understanding of Dhamma, you letting go of all that conditioning, all those assumptions, all those conventions, you're not getting rid, you're not. You're not annihilating. You're letting go. And in that letting go is the realization of the deathless. And so then there's nothing more to fear because you have taken an interest in the Dhamma or the way things are. And then that will also give you the faith and the trust to persevere. Even through the difficult patches of life. You find you have tremendous ability to use even the worst things that happen to you. Instead of being that which ruins your life. Sometimes it's that which awakens you to truth.



Ajahn Sumedho - **01:03:20**

And many people have told me that sometimes, like a. Some of the. Like a terminal illness or some terrible thing that's happened to them has actually awakened them rather than ruined their lives. And that's because they suddenly, they. They. They were. It jolted them out of maybe the momentum of just habitual behavior. They had to look at something in a different way. And now, here, in terms of Dhamma, what I'm encouraging you to do is to develop the way of looking at things in terms of the Dhamma of the way it is. And that allows you to have the understanding, the perspective on the personal experiences, the unique, the eccentric, the odd, the unexpected things that happen to us, as well as the ordinary habitual tendencies and functions of life.



Ajahn Sumedho - **01:04:19**

We see it then in terms of the way it is, rather than the way we think it is. So I offer this as a reflection for this afternoon. Time now for tea and 15 minutes. We can then reassemble for further discussion.